Stay Gold

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/56711269.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Netossa (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Falling In Love, Angst, Childhood Trauma, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Drummer Catra, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Human, Adora is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver's A+ Parenting, Fluff and Angst, mostly fluff tho, look at these idiots

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Part 1 of Just One More Kiss

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by d0c_save_us_all

Summary

A voice calls out from behind her. “You really got to hit it.”

“Sorry!” Catra yelps, jumping off of the stool, nearly knocking it over as Adora rushes in front of her protectively, reaching one arm out and putting herself between Catra and the stranger in a well practiced motion. Catra put her hands behind her back, and looked down at the floor in shame.

Standing in front of her is a tall woman with dark skin and dyed, bluish white hair. She’s cocking her hip, and her pierced left eyebrow is raised in confusion. Catra didn’t even know eyebrows could be pierced. She thinks she wants one. “What are you apologizing for, kid?”

“Uh, touching the drums.” She responds.

—

Or, where Catra discovers the drums.

Notes

Content Warning: Child Abuse

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra is 12 years old when she discovers the drums.

Catra and Adora almost always walk home together after school. It was a long walk, and it's not odd for them to duck into a store or two to wait out the cold October rain. Even if it means a hail of questions from Weaver, and more often than not, a date with her belt.

They do that today, ducking into a music store as the sky crackles with thunder above them.

The store is packed wall to wall with instruments. Guitars, violins, just everything Catra could think of, and more. A large drum kit sits in the back of the room.

Adora tentatively plucks a guitar string with her finger. She's somehow spooked at how the snaps back to produce a thin, weedy twang.

Catra can't help but laugh at her. Adora pouts, crossing her arms and *hmph*-ing at her in a way that would be cute if it wasn't so infuriating.

Curious, Catra approaches the drum kit, and gently tapped the drum heads with the tips of her fingers. She listens in wonder how the hum of each drum fades out, and how the cymbals shimmer when she taps on them with her fingernail.

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“Uh, touching the drums.” She responds.

The woman seems even more confused now. “Why would you be sorry for that?”

“Because uh…” Catra trails off, “I don’t know.”

The woman chuckles, “This is a music store, you’re supposed to touch it, you know?”

“Oh,” Catra's eyes flick to Adora, who’d gingerly stepped back from her position between them.

“Do you want to try out the drumset?” the woman asks, leaning down with her hands on her knees. She extends her arm, holding out a pair of drumsticks. Catra looks to Adora, but Adora is too busy staring down the stranger to notice Catra’s silent plea. Catra takes the safe bet of remaining silent. For all she knows, it could be a trick.

The woman’s expression shifts from one of relaxed amusement to one of concern. Her gaze darts between Catra and Adora before sighing and shaking her head in disappointment. She takes a step closer to Catra, and Catra flinches when she does. Adults getting closer to her after she doesn’t tell them what they want to hear doesn’t mean anything good.

The woman gently offers the drumsticks to Catra, and seeing no better option, she accepts, awkwardly holding the sticks in her hands.

“What’s your name kid?” the woman asks, shooting Catra an easy smile.

Catra doesn’t want to trust her. The last time she trusted someone other than Adora was her case worker, and that ended with him calling Catra a liar to her face after she showed him the bruises from Ms. Weaver’s belt.

But there is something about this woman that's… different. Something more relaxed, straightforward, earnest. And it's not like this woman can hurt her. She looks to Adora, and she flashes Catra a reassuring smile. Her stomach feels like it's filling with light, and she looks away, studying the carpet.

"Catra." She responds, once that feeling has died down a little.

"Nice to meet you, Catra. My name's Netossa." The woman shakes Catra's hand as she guides her to the drum stool. Her grip is firm, but not crushingly strong. "Now let me show you how to hold this. It's pretty easy."

"You don't want to grab onto it, you want the sticks to bounce a bit in your hand." Netossa adjusts her fingers slightly. "You want to balance them just right." She shifts the stick a fraction of an inch in Catra's hand. "Perfect."

Netossa gestures toward the stool with her hands, and it takes a second for Catra to realize that she's inviting her to sit down, and another for Catra to cautiously do so. Adora smiles a wide, toothy smile, and gives her a thumbs up. It makes Catra's heart flutter.

"You want earplugs, kid?" Netossa asks, and that snaps Catra out of her daze. "They can get pretty loud." Netossa emphasizes the *t's* in *pretty*, and it makes Catra giggle.

“No thanks.” She responds. She doesn’t like how they make her ears feel anyway.

“Okay,” Netossa starts, pointing at the thin, metal drum right in front of her. She flips up a lever on it, and there is a sound not unlike the crinkling of dry rice for a split second. “This is called a snare drum. I want you to hit it, okay? Just one smooth motion. Can I touch your arm for a sec?” Netossa asks. Catra nods, and Netossa moves her elbows slightly outward. “Okay, hit it.”

Catra swings her arm down, and the stick hits the snare drum with a bright, painfully loud crack. The stick flies out of her hand, dropping to the floor.

Netossa snickers, but it surprisingly doesn’t feel mean. “Don’t worry kid, that happens to everyone. Grip it a little tighter, and let's try again?”

Catra looks up to Adora, and she’s still smiling at her, hands clenched together in expectation. Catra picks up the stick and wraps her fingers around it in the way Netossa told her to, balancing it in her fingers. She just grips it firmly this time. She takes a swing.

It hits halfway between the center and the edge of the drum, and the loud *crack* rings out for a split second. She hits the center of the drum again, and the ringing tone is gone. It’s softer, not as snappy as hitting off center. She likes the *crack* more.

“Not bad, not bad.” Netossa smiles, gently stilling Catra’s hand before she can hit the drum again. “Want me to teach you a drum beat?”

Catra nods, and Netossa points to her foot.

“Okay, can you put your foot on that pedal right there?” Netossa asks, “Good, okay, push your foot down on it.

The thing attached to the pedal smacks into the big drum in front of her. The drum thumps loudly, and she can almost feel the shockwave in her chest.

“Now put your left hand over the snare, just like that” Netossa nods. “Perfect!”

“And you see this little thing right here?” She points to the thing that looks like two tiny cymbals stacked on top of another. “It’s called a hi hat. Now, reach over with your right hand. It should cross over your left.” She gently grabs her wrists in a way that doesn’t make her flinch, moving her hands until they are crossed over one another. “Good!” Netossa smiles reassuringly.

“So I’m going to clap my hands and count, and you are gonna press down on that pedal on every clap, okay?” Netossa asks. Catra looks to Adora again, who is staring at them, enraptured. Catra nods.

Netossa claps slowly, and counts *one and two and three and four and*. Catra does her best to follow it with the pedal, but it takes a few counts for her to actually start following the beat.

Once Catra gets it, she stops. “Okay. So I want you to hit the hi hat.” She points to the thing that looks like two golden dishes stacked on top of each other, “on every one and three.”

Catra does her best to follow along, and as Netossa tells her to hit the snare on two and four, she realizes something.

She isn’t bad at this. She isn’t a failure at this. She can actually be good at something, good for something, once in her life.

After she finally coughs up a hokey, little off kilter drumbeat, she looks up from the kit, smiling with pride for what feels like the first time in her life.

More importantly, Adora is staring at her. She looks entirely captivated, a stupid, soft smile on her face. Their eyes meet. Adora’s eyes widened in shock, a slight blush dusting her cheeks as she looks away.

Catra can’t bring herself to look away. She feels different, changed.

It’s like Adora lit a candle in her chest. It doesn’t fade while the rain lets up and they have to walk home. It just burns more intensely with every word that Adora speaks. It brightens when Adora smiles and jokes, and it burns when they touch. It expands when Adora laughs, spreading to the rest of her body.

Catra isn’t sure what it is, but she wants more of it.

It doesn’t flicker when Weaver lashes her until her body is slick with blood. It doesn’t dim when Weaver tells her how worthless, stupid, and pathetic she is when she cries. She holds onto it as the second set of lashes and kicks chip one of her teeth and make her eye swell up until she can’t see well.

When Catra limps to their bed that night, Adora pulls her in close, holding her tight and running her hands through Catra’s messy hair.

“You were really good today. When you were playing.” Adora whispers, “I liked it.”

The candle swells into a raging bonfire as a smile blooms across Adora’s beautiful face.

She’ll make Adora smile for the rest of her life, if she can help it.

End Notes

Thanks for reading. Feel free to comment if you enjoyed it. More coming… eventually I guess.

Title is from the song Stay Gold by Buck-Tick

Special thanks to TheNotebookWizard and erratictransparency for beta'ing on such short notice.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!